one of our satellites from hundreds of miles out in space. Someone thought I'd enjoy seeing them.

Our space satellites provided invaluable information to us in helping to assess the military strength of other countries. Through use of satellites and other technologies, we had great ability to learn things about nations that were hostile to us. We also had human intelligence agents—brave men and women whose names the American people will never read or hear—who risked their lives and prevented potentially devastating acts of terrorism against our country when I was president. Even now I cannot disclose details of these operations, because it would compromise people still at work.

Yet, as good as our space-age technology was; as great an intelligence service as the CIA became under Bill Casey; as powerful as America was militarily, I learned, as had President Carter, how helpless the head of the most powerful nation on earth can feel when it comes to the seemingly simple task of trying to find and bring home an American citizen held against his will in a distant land.

The terrorists who kidnapped our citizens in Lebanon relocated them frequently, usually at night, keeping them dispersed in different buildings, always on the move. Our intelligence community occasionally had a little success in trying to infiltrate the Middle Eastern terrorist groups, but never enough. There were dozens of these groups that shared a hatred for the United States. Some were splinter groups of splinter groups. It was extremely difficult to pinpoint which particular organization of cutthroats was responsible for a specific terrorist act. Most kept constantly in motion, taking refuge among the civilian populations of cities or hiding out in remote desert or mountain strongholds. Sometimes a group would claim credit for an outrage it hadn't committed; sometimes, two or three groups claimed responsibility for the same atrocity.